

LAW FIRST: Chaudhry surrounded by supporters at his residence

hours after Ghazi was killed—Pakistan resonated with the sounds of revenge suicide and roadside bomb attacks across the country.

So far, more than 300 people, mostly army and police force personnel, have died in the revenge attacks, majority of which have occurred in the restive tribal belt along the border with Afghanistan. But there have also been attacks in Islamabad and in Hub to the south, which targeted a convoy of Chinese engineers and killed the accompanying policemen and bystanders. The situation is so volatile that the entire country has been put on a state of red alert. Even as another attempt was made on his life, Musharraf himself declared at a high-level meeting that "this is now an open war between the extremists and the moderates".

In particular, most analysts agree that Musharraf's fight with the Islamist radicals has entered a decisive phase. "We have to move swiftly, or North-West Frontier Province (NWFP) will fall to the Taliban," warned a confidential Interior Ministry report. Subsequently,

the Government has decided to strike at parts of NWFP and tribal regions such as Waziristan, where it believes the bomb attacks are being planned. The US, which had been unhappy about 'peace pacts' in the tribal areas such as South Waziristan, has offered intelligence and logistical support.

But this is also a tricky situation for Musharraf. On the one hand, it is clear that the Lal Masjid brothers had close links with militants connected with Al-Qaeda, such as the fugitive Baitullah Mehsud and Zawahiri himself. Many of those who died in Lal Masjid were known militants of the banned Jaish-e-Mohammad which is also part of the extremist continuum of groups with links to Al Qaeda. And Stratfor, the American intelligence think-tank, theorises that Zawahiri's immediate statement about Lal Masjid betrayed a sense of panic that his space of operation may soon be curtailed. Many analysts believe that the suicide attacks are an attempt by the militants to take the battle to the Pakistan government forces, in effect to relieve building pressure on

sponsible", the foreign office has been quick to warn the US against such an adventure. The last thing Musharraf wants is being accused of selling out Pakistani sovereignty.

Of it still remains to be seen how the restoration of the chief justice plays out for the General. A number of important cases are likely to come up before the SC by September, and many in the Opposition have become optimistic about them ever since the reassertion of judiciary. Not least among these is a probable case challenging Musharraf's attempts to hold on to his uniform as president and his stated intention to stand for re-election from the current assemblies. Both of these have been vociferously condemned by the Opposition. Cases are also likely to be filed by Benazir Bhutto's Pakistan People's Party (PPP) and Nawaz Sharif's Pakistan Muslim League (PML-N) challenging the debarring of their exiled leaders from contesting for prime ministership for a third term and the preparations for the general elections due by January. The PPP is also likely to go to court against Bhutto's corruption cases.

So far, the General seems to have played the restoration of the chief justice sensibly. Government lawyers had already shifted the blame for the reference on to the prime minister during the course of the hearings. Calls are being made for some heads to roll and the first in the firing line are likely to be the law minister and law secretary. However, Musharraf may also draw some satisfaction from the divide within the Opposition. Significantly, Bhutto, unlike the other Opposition leaders, has not called for Musharraf's resignation and did not allow PPP to join the All Parties Democratic Movement established in London by Sharif. She has also said that she was "more worried about the threat to the state (from extremism) than to democracy". This has led to a much analysed rift within the Opposition and rumours are rife about a Bhutto-Musharraf deal. But time is running short and Bhutto is also under pressure from within the rank and file of PPP not to be seen as selling out to Musharraf. How he fares in his war with the extremists and whether the deal with PPP actually materialises may determine whether his days are numbered. ■

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AP PHOTO: MOHAMMAD ZUBAIR

them in their hideouts. In that, most people would understand a reaction from the Government. But on the other hand, Musharraf also cannot ignore the political fallout of a situation in which the Pakistan Army is attacking its own people. He is already under fire for tacitly supporting American air strikes from across the Afghan border, like the one on an alleged Taliban training camp in the Shawal mountains in North Waziristan, which killed 34 people that locals claim were innocent.

The reaction of the highly charged Pukhtoon population of the tribal belt—most of the seminaries students at Lal Masjid were Pukhtoons from remote and poor areas—to further "collateral damage" from attacks in tribal areas and NWFP must also be factored into the equation. Unsurprisingly, Islamabad has been vocal about its irritation at the US statements calling for direct American action in the tribal belt. Calling such statements "highly irre-